To me the combat dress symbolizes the dress of warriors. I believe that it ought to be given the same importance as the ceremonial dress. Therefore, I felt that the standardization of army uniforms, specially the battle fatigues, was an imperative need. We decided on a different cloth and camouflage pattern, based on the advice of professionals in the field of fabrics, and to prevent unauthorized usage, put the logo of the Indian Army on the fabric itself. We also standardized the belts and combat shoes and the manner of wearing the trousers – they had to be tucked into the boots. During my service in combat situations, I sometimes felt that we were two armies – one fighting terrorists or guarding the borders, facing bullets and braving hazards, and the other in higher HQs or in peaceful cantonments. They wore different uniforms. Its a fact of life that the higher the HQ, the more remote it is from the hardships being faced by those fighting it out, whether against the terrorists or in harsh living conditions.

Once, while I was commanding the brigade in Kashmir, we had a serious casualty in a counterinfiltration operation. This wounded soldier's life was at stake and we needed to evacuate him to the hospital at Srinagar even though it had become dark and the road protection was not in place. However, at the Corps HQ no responsible staff officer was available who could authorize us to move the convoy at night. This was because there was a party going on in the Corps HQ – some dining out or the other. But surely there must have been a duty officer. Whose war were we fighting anyway? I said to myself. Finally, after getting no response, only when I asked to be put through to the corps commander, did someone come on the line and we got the OK. A life was saved.

Therefore, I made it a point as the army chief to wear the combat dress with much pride and elan whenever I visited field formations or forward areas. Besides, in a display of camaraderie and to empathize with approximately 300,000 men in arms serving in the operational areas, it was decided by me that the rest of the army would wear the combat dress every Friday. To be honest, it did create quite an impact not only amongst the services but also in the ministry of defence. The people definitely welcomed this initiative.